



Messaging Matters

Choosing the right email messaging suite to help keep your business on top

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The Post-PC era is unfolding right as you read this, and these are times when accessing your email is no longer limited to a PC terminal fixed to your desk in office or at home. You want email access on your smartphone, tablet and laptop, as you cycle through them at different points of time on any given day. Your employees will have similar needs and habits, wanting to bring those devices to work, the ones they're comfortable using and boost productivity. It's the reality and it's happening all around us.

Deploying a Microsoft Exchange Server is too cumbersome, especially if you don't have enough people in your organization

– for a SOHO setup, an Exchange Server is overkill, anyways. And relying on free email services like Gmail, Yahoo or Rediff doesn't bode well as far as brand impression goes – imagine trying to send a mail through a prospective client through Gmail, trying to convince them to take you seriously as a business outfit? It's a losing battle. First things first, you need to buy a domain and fire your own email solution on it.

Everyone's favourite free email and collaboration suite just became paid – yes, Google Apps for businesses is no longer available as a free service. What's more, its paid avatar is quite expensive – US \$50 per user per year or US \$5 per user per month. If yours is a small business set up, or you work out of your home, Google Apps may no longer be an economical option.

Time to look for other options.

Hosted email

Large-scale domain registrars like GoDaddy and BigRock offer certain number of free email addresses while you signup for a web hosting plan. While they may look very attractive on the surface, most of them have a catch. Email addresses promised while buying server space is often shared, meaning if you're getting 10 free email addresses on your hosting plan, chances are that they will all have to share a storage space of 100MB to 1GB – not individually, but as a group. With just a few megabytes for each account, you'll be frustrated and pulling your hair out in no time – not a good situation to be in if you're running an online business.

Alternatively, what you should explore are dedicated email solutions that companies like BigRock and GoDaddy offer. BigRock, especially, lets you fire up an online email account for a custom domain of your choice for as little as ₹39 per month if you sign up for 10 years at once. For that you get 10 email accounts with 2GB of storage space for each account, and features like POP3 and IMAP, besides the ability to login and check your email through a web browser. You can configure the email on Outlook or Thunderbird, be assured that spam and virus filtering is in place, basically enjoy the benefits of a full-fledged modern email and messaging system that is accessible on mobile devices like Blackberry and iPhone.

You will enjoy similar benefits on a GoDaddy email plan, but it will only cost a lot more – ₹119 per month (for 5 years) for 5 email addresses with 2GB of storage each. Another difference we found between the two email solution providers is that GoDaddy offers added features like text mail support, 256-bit encryption for emails, and a desktop notifier – features that BigRock doesn't highlight on its website. So GoDaddy, in a way, tries to justify its cost by giving you bonus features; however, how important they may be to your business environment is something only you can decide and act upon.

Both BigRock and GoDaddy are trusted names in the field of domain registration and web hosting, and we have no hesitation in recommending them as avenues worth exploring. A typical process for signing up